Can and can't: abilities

Nombre: _____ Fecha: _____

Qué vas a aprender

- Say what you can and can't do (lo que sabes y no sabes hacer)
- Use can with all persons without -s
- Ask «Can you...?» and give short answers
- Describe the abilities of animals and people

Para pensar

Un pez sabe nadar, pero no sabe trepar a un árbol. Un mono sí trepa, pero nada fatal. ¿Cómo dirías en inglés lo que cada uno sabe hacer?

Explicación

What does can mean?

We use can to talk about **abilities**: things that we know how to do or that we are able to do. «I **can** ride a bike», «My baby sister **can** walk», «Birds **can** fly».

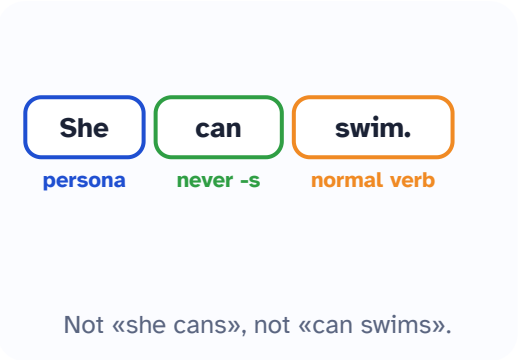
En castellano: *can* se traduce como «puedo» o «sé»: «I can swim» es «sé nadar». En español usamos «saber» para lo que hemos aprendido (sé leer) y «poder» para lo que somos capaces de hacer (puedo levantar esto). En inglés, para las dos cosas basta con una palabra: **can**.



Can: the same for everybody

The great thing about *can* is that it **never changes**. It's the same with all persons: I can, you can, **he can**, **she can**, it can, we can, they can. We never say «she cans».

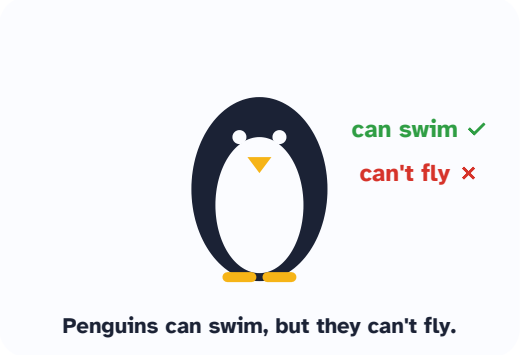
After *can*, the verb goes in its **normal form**, without *to* and without -s: «She can **swim**», not «She can swims» or «She can to swim». **En castellano:** el orden es igual que en español: «ella sabe nadar» → «she can swim».



Can't: the negative

To say that you are **not able** to do something, use `can't` (or **cannot**, written together): «I **can't** whistle» (no sé silbar), «Penguins **can't** fly», «My grandpa **can't** use the computer».

We often use *but* to join a positive and a negative sentence: «I can swim, **but** I can't dive». **Pronunciación:** en inglés británico, *can't* suena con una «a» larga («cant»), y *can* suena más corto y débil. Escucha bien la **t** final para saber si es afirmativa o negativa.



Action verbs

To talk about abilities, we need *action verbs*. Here are some useful ones: **run** (correr), **jump** (saltar), **swim** (nadar), **climb** (trepar), **dance** (bailar), **sing** (cantar), **skate** (patinar), **ride a bike** (montar en bici), **play the guitar** (tocar la guitarra), **cook** (cocinar), **draw** (dibujar), **whistle** (silbar).

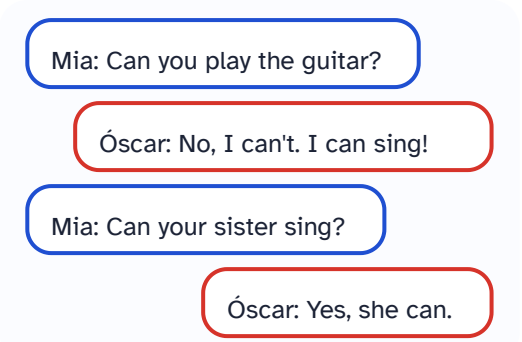
Act them out: one person mimes a verb and the others guess. «You can **skate**!». Moving your body helps you remember the words.



Questions: Can you...?

To ask about abilities, put Can at the beginning: «**Can** you swim?», «**Can** your dog jump high?», «**Can** they speak English?». We don't need *do* or *does*: *can* is a helper itself.

Short answers: «**Yes, I can.**» / «**No, I can't.**», «**Yes, it can.**» / «**No, it can't.**». **En castellano:** «¿Sabes nadar?» → «Can you swim?». Fíjate que solo se cambia el orden: *can* pasa delante de la persona.



How well? Very well, quite well, a little

We can say **how well** we do something with these words at the end of the sentence: «I can swim very well» (muy bien), «I can draw **quite well**» (bastante bien), «I can cook **a little**» (un poco), «I can't dance **at all**» (nada de nada).

This is useful to be honest and precise. Nobody can do everything perfectly! **En castellano:** no digas «very good» para esto: *good* describe cosas (a good book) y *well* describe cómo se hace algo (I sing well).



Amazing animals

Animals have incredible abilities. A **cheetah** can run very fast. A **kangaroo** can jump very far, but it can't walk backwards. A **dolphin** can swim and jump out of the

water. A **parrot** can talk, a **spider** can make webs and a **chameleon** can change colour.

But there are things they can't do: elephants can't jump, snakes can't hear like us and ostriches can't fly, although they are birds. **Reto:** busca un animal y escribe dos cosas que *can* y una que *can't* hacer.

Animal	can ✓	can't ✗
kangaroo	jump	walk backwards
ostrich	run	fly
parrot	talk	swim
elephant	swim	jump

Reading: our talent show

Read the poster: «**Talent Show!** Friday at 5 p.m. in the school hall. Come and see our stars! **Marta** can juggle with five balls. **Yusuf** can play the violin very well. The twins **Leo and Pau** can dance hip hop, but they can't sing. **Carmen** can't dance, but she can tell very funny jokes. And our teacher, **Mr Ruiz**, can do magic tricks! Can you do something special? Talk to Mr Ruiz before Wednesday.»

Answer: Who can play the violin? Can the twins sing? What can Mr Ruiz do?

Talent Show

- **Marta** — can juggle
- **Yusuf** — can play the violin
- **Leo and Pau** — can dance, can't sing
- **Carmen** — can tell jokes

Let's practise: find someone who...

Play **Find someone who...** Your teacher gives you a card with abilities: «Find someone who can whistle», «...who can touch their nose with their tongue», «...who can count to 20 in English», «...who can stand on one leg for 30 seconds».

Walk around the class and ask: «**Can you whistle?**». If they answer «**Yes, I can**», they show you and you write their name. At the end, report: «Ana can whistle. Pedro can't whistle, but he can stand on one leg». ¡Gana quien complete antes la tarjeta!

Find someone who can...

- **whistle** — Ana
- **count to 20** — Pedro
- **stand on one leg** —
- **draw a horse** —

Can and can't

affirmative	negative	question	how well
CAN	**CAN'T**	**CAN...?**	**WELL**
I can swim. She can swim.	I can't fly. = cannot	Can you skate? Yes, I can.	very well a little

Ejercicios

1. **Translate: correr, saltar, trepar, silbar.**

2. **Complete: «Fish ___ swim.» (sí)**

3. **Complete: «Elephants ___ jump.» (no)**

4. **Make a question: «You can play chess.»**

5. **Short answer (yes): «Can your dad cook?»**

6. **Short answer (no): «Can they skate?»**

7. **Correct: «My sister can plays the piano.»**

8. **Join with but: «I can draw.» «I can't paint.»**

9. **Write the opposite of «very well».**

10. **Write two things you can do and one you can't.**

Practica

1. **«Sé nadar» is...**

   A) I swim can.

   B) I cans swim.

   C) I can swim.

2. **«She ___ ride a bike.»**

   A) can

   B) cans

   C) can to

3. **«Penguins ___ fly.»**

   A) can

   B) can't

   C) don't can

4. **Which question is correct?**

   A) Do you can dance?

   B) Can you dance?

   C) You can dance?

5. **Short answer: «Can he sing?» (yes)**

   A) Yes, he cans.

   B) Yes, he sings.

   C) Yes, he can.

6. **«Trepar» is...**

   A) climb

   B) jump

   C) skate

7. **«I can draw ___.» (muy bien)**

   A) very good

   B) very much

   C) very well

8. **The full form of «can't» is...**

   A) can not to

B) cannot

C) no can

9. **Which animal can't fly?**

A) ostrich

B) eagle

C) parrot

10. **«They can ___ English.»**

A) speak

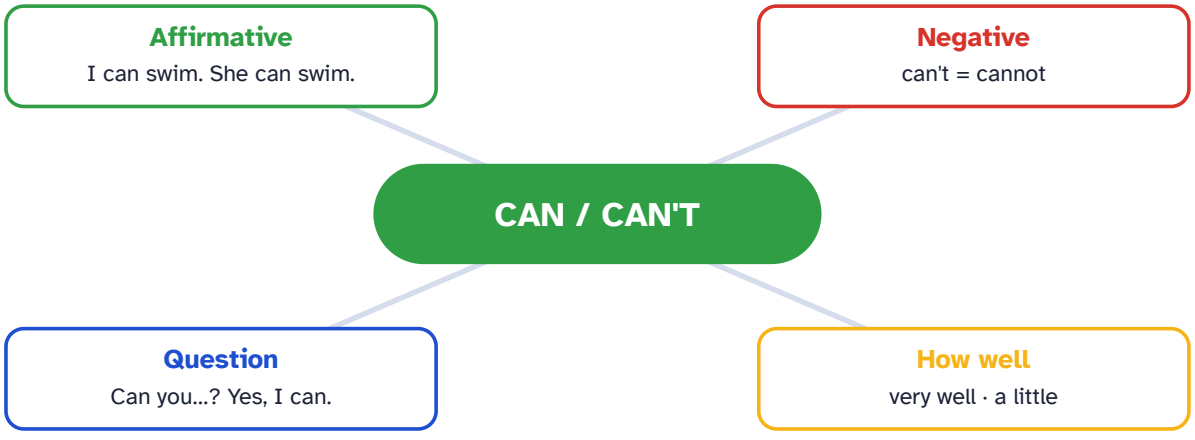
B) speaks

C) to speak

Explícalo con tus palabras

Incluye: Qué significa can y para qué sirve; Por qué can no cambia con he, she o it; Cómo se dice que no sabes hacer algo; Cómo se pregunta con Can you y cómo se contesta.

Resumen



Tarjetas de repaso

Recórtalas: pregunta delante, respuesta detrás.

can

Poder / saber hacer algo.

can't

No poder (= cannot).

She can swim

can no lleva -s; el verbo tampoco.

Can you…?

Pregunta sin do.

Yes, I can.

Respuesta corta afirmativa.

No, I can't.

Respuesta corta negativa.

very well

Muy bien (cómo se hace).

climb

Trepar.

Soluciones

1. **C)** can + verbo.
2. **A)** can nunca cambia.
3. **B)** No pueden volar.
4. **B)** Can delante.
5. **C)** Yes, he can.
6. **A)** climb.
7. **C)** well = bien (cómo).
8. **B)** cannot, junto.
9. **A)** El avestruz no vuela.
10. **A)** Verbo normal.

Soluciones de los ejercicios

1. run, jump, climb, whistle.
2. can.
3. can't.
4. Can you play chess?
5. Yes, he can.
6. No, they can't.
7. My sister can play the piano.
8. I can draw, but I can't paint.
9. not at all.
10. Model answer: I can ride a bike. I can swim quite well. I can't play the guitar.